An IPS officer of the 1951 batch (Andhra cadre), Nagrani came on deputation to the Government of India at SP rank, first to the CRPF. Soon afterwards he joined the Intelligence Bureau as assistant director in charge of the SFF. On bifurcation of the Intelligence Bureau and creation of the Research and Analysis Wing in September 1968, he moved over to the R&AW, where he served in various capacities both in India and abroad. He finally took over as DGS in 1982. Normally, the director of the R&AW used to be the ex-officio DGS too. But, as Nagrani was a 1951 IPS (regular recruitment) officer, and as Director Gary Saxena, entering service through the special recruitment quota, was given 1950-1/2 seniority, it was decided to give independent charge of DGS to Nagrani to oversee the affairs of the SFF, the Special Service Bureau (SSB) and the Aviation Research Centre (ARC).

The SFF, in addition to having a large contingent of persons of Tibetan origin meant specifically for Tibet-related operations, had a highly trained professional commando unit to deal with hostage taking or other serious situations resulting from terrorist activities. This commando unit comprised 150 young men, 50 per cent of them on short-term deputation from the army, and the rest from the BSF and CRPF. The cell had two Mi4 helicopters for heliborne operations. Besides, it had the facility to use suitable aircraft from the Aviation Research Centre as and when required.

Incidentally, when the Sikkim guards were being disarmed by the Indian army on 9 April 1975 at Gangtok, Nagrani, as staff officer to the R&AW Secretary R.N. Kao, had called me to seek a ‘blow by blow’ account of the disarming operation for the benefit of his boss.

Soon after the assassination of Indira Gandhi, Nagrani was asked to raise a distinct new commando force, the National Security Guard (NSG) as its first director general. He raised it with the help of some SFF commandos and clerical and ministerial staff, who formed the core of the newly created outfit.

Nagrani told me that it was towards the end of December 1983 that Kao called him to his office and asked him to plan an SFF-led heliborne operation to abduct Bhindranwale from the roof of the Golden Temple’s langar (dining complex), where he delivered daily sermons till late evening, and whisk him away with the help of the